

Urdu, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to contemporary
Urdu

Adhithya Rajasekaran

Starter edition — six short chapters, with more being written.

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons
Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Urdu is set in
Noto Naskh Arabic (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This book teaches Urdu one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It assumes no Urdu and no Perso-Arabic script: every section takes one small expression, introduces only the letters, sounds, and grammar that expression needs, connects it to words you may already know, and ends by asking for it back. Urdu reads right to left — but you will be reading real words long before you have met the whole alphabet.

Urdu makes several histories visible at once. Its grammar and much of its everyday vocabulary are Indo-Aryan, closely related to Hindi, while Persian and Arabic have contributed a large literary and formal layer on top. Etymology in this book is a memory aid — never a claim that a borrowed word is any less fully Urdu today.

One honest note about the type. Urdu is traditionally printed in the flowing, descending *Nastaliq* style. This edition sets it in Naskh instead, which is legible and reproduces identically everywhere, while a suitable Nastaliq face is found. The language, the joining behaviour, and the right-to-left order are Urdu; only the style of the letterforms is not, and it seemed better to say so than to let you assume otherwise.

This is a starter edition: six short chapters, complete in themselves, with more being written.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Urdu out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it

stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 — share it, adapt it, teach from it.

Contents

Preface	iii
1 Greetings and responses	1
1.1 سلام (<i>salām</i>) — hello through peace	1
1.2 شكريه (<i>shukriyā</i>) — thank you	2
1.3 جی ہاں (<i>jī hā</i>) — yes, respectfully	2
1.4 نہیں (<i>nahī</i>) — no, and later not	3
2 Give your name	5
2.1 میرا نام ... ہے — my name is	5
3 Ask and Answer Names	7
3.1 āp / tum / tū	7
3.2 kyā	8
3.3 āp kā nām kyā hai?	9
3.4 āp se mil kar khushī huī	10
3.5 Practice	11
4 How Are You?	13
4.1 kaise / kaisī	13
4.2 āp kaise haiñ? / āp kaisī haiñ?	14
4.3 main ... hūñ	15
4.4 ṭhīk	15
4.5 main ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā	16
4.6 Practice	17
5 Take Leave	19
5.1 khudā	19
5.2 hāfiz	20
5.3 khudā hāfiz	21

5.4 Practice	22
6 Five Verbs at the Core	23
6.1 honā	23
6.2 jānā	24
6.3 ānā	26
6.4 bolnā	27
6.5 jānnā	28
A note on sources	31

Chapter 1

Greetings and responses

This chapter builds one miniature exchange in dependency order: greet, thank, answer yes, answer no. Four short expressions establish right-to-left reading, joining, omitted short vowels, long vowels, respectful *jī*, and one Urdu nasal sign. Companion lessons: UR-C01-*.md.

1.1 سلام (*salām*) — hello through peace

Read only what this expression needs

Urdu runs **right to left**. Read سلام from its right edge: س *s*, ل *l*, ā long ā, م *m*. Letters usually join inside a word. The tall *l* does not connect to the following letter, so the final م begins a new stroke group. No other letters are due yet.

Where the expression came from

Salām is a greeting and the word “peace.” Urdu received it through the Persian-Arabic literary world. Its consonants **s-l-m** belong to a Semitic family concerned with peace, safety, and wholeness. Persian *salām*, Arabic *salām*, and Hebrew *shalom* make the historical family especially visible.

Use it now

Say سلام to begin a friendly exchange. For now the safest reply is the same word: A says سلام; B answers سلام. One useful move is enough.

One-minute checkpoint

Read سلام from right to left. Which letter carries long *ā*? Point to ل, cover the romanization, and say *salām* once.

1.2 شکریہ (*shukriyā*) — thank you**Read only what this expression needs**

Urdu normally leaves short vowels unmarked. Read the visible guide: ش *sh*, ک *k*, ر *r*, ی *y/i*, ہ final *h*-shape. The learned whole supplies the short *u* and *i*, while the ending is pronounced long *ā*. First remember one joined word, not every possible letter form.

Where the expression came from

The central consonants **sh–k–r** belong to the Arabic family for gratitude; Arabic *shukran* is a close comparison. Urdu *shukriyā* reflects its long Persian-Arabic lexical history and is an ordinary modern Urdu expression.

Use it now

Build a two-step chain: سلام *salām* — hello; شکریہ *shukriyā* — thank you. Keep the second word in three light beats: *shuk-ri-yā*.

One-minute checkpoint

Which new letter begins شکریہ? Point to ش, say *sh*, then produce *salām* — *shukriyā* without looking.

1.3 جی ہاں (*jī hā*) — yes, respectfully**Read only what this expression needs**

This answer has two small words. In جی, ج gives *j* and ی stretches the vowel to *ī*. In ہاں, the final ہ is **nūn ghunna**: it nasalizes long *ā* rather than adding a strong English *n*. Let a little air pass through the nose.

Use it now

ہاں means “yes.” Adding جی makes the response attentive and respectful; جی can also answer by itself. Learn the safely courteous whole first: جی ہاں *jī hā*.

One-minute checkpoint

Which final sign nasalizes the vowel? Point to ں. Then answer politely: جی ہاں.

1.4 نہیں (*nahī*) — no, and later not**Read only what this expression needs**

Reuse ہ, ی, and nasal ں; add ن *n* at the right edge. The result is نہیں *nahī*. Stretch *ī* slightly and nasalize it; do not add a separate forceful *n* at the end.

Where the expression came from

Unlike the Persian-Arabic vocabulary that opened the chapter, *nahī* belongs to Urdu’s inherited Indo-Aryan core. Hindi *nahī* is the same spoken word written in a different script. The shared form previews close grammatical kinship without making Hindi script a prerequisite.

Use it now

As a complete answer, نہیں means “no.” Inside a later sentence it will also mean “not,” but that second job can wait. Contrast only: جی ہاں — yes; نہیں — no.

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce the chain hello, thank you, yes, no. Then read سلام, شکریہ, جی ہاں, نہیں in the same order.

Chapter 2

Give your name

The first chapter supplied social moves. This one adds one sentence and one word-order fact: Urdu places the present copula at the end. Companion lesson: UR-C02-mera-naam.md.

2.1 میرا نام ... ہے — my name is ...

Read the Urdu phrase from right to left while keeping its spoken word order:

میرا نام سارا ہے۔
merā nām Sārā hai — My name is Sara.

Read only what this expression needs

Nearly every shape is recycled. میرا begins with م from سلام, then reuses ی, ر, and ا. نام reuses ن, ا, and م. In final ہے, the only new form is ے, called *barī ye*; here the whole word is pronounced *hai*. Learn that diphthong with the word.

Use it now

Assemble four slots:

1. میرا *merā* — my;
2. نام *nām* — name;
3. your name;
4. ہے *hai* — is.

The reusable pattern is **my** + **name** + **NAME** + **is**. Urdu places *hai* at the end. Replace Sara with your name and keep every other slot.

Where the expression came from

Nām continues an old Indo-Aryan form related to Sanskrit *nāman* and, much farther back, English *name*. The possessive *merā* and copula *hai* also belong to Urdu’s inherited grammar. The sentence therefore follows the Indo-Aryan layer that Urdu shares closely with Hindi, even though Urdu writes it in the Perso-Arabic script.

One-minute checkpoint

Where does “is” go? At the end. Point to **ۛ**, then replace Sara with your own name and say the full four-slot sentence once.

What is deliberately deferred

Urdu possessives agree with the noun they describe; *merā* has this form because *nām* is grammatically masculine, not because of the speaker’s gender. That rule, other possessive forms, and the rest of the copula paradigm belong to later lessons. The fixed introduction works for every speaker now.

Chapter 3

Ask and Answer Names

3.1 آپ / تم / تو — three relationships inside “you”

Say **merā nām ... hai** with your own name. To ask the other person’s name, begin with the respectful form.

You’ll want to know first — three forms

Urdu	read	use
آپ	<i>āp</i>	respectful: a new adult, elder, or anyone you wish to honor
تم	<i>tum</i>	familiar: friends and peers
تو	<i>tū</i>	intimate, or downward; unsafe as a beginner default

آپ begins with Ā, an alif carrying the long *ā* mark, then پ *p*. تم and تو share ت *t*. In تو, و carries long *ū*.

Grammar Lens: choose the relationship first

English flattened these choices into one *you*. Urdu keeps three. Use **āp** in a first meeting. Move to **tum** when the relationship supports familiarity. Save **tū** for relationships where you already know it is welcome; used badly, it can sound belittling.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Tum/tū belong to the old Indo-European familiar-“you” family: Sanskrit *tvam*, English **thou**, and Latin *tū* are relatives. **Āp** followed another route: a word connected with “self/oneself” became honorific address.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a new adult — **āp**
- a friend — **tum**
- the old family — **tum, tvam, thou**

Before you move on

Which form is safest when unsure? (**Āp**.) Which familiar forms share history with English *thou*? (**Tum/tū**.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Cultural Notes*.

3.2 کیا — what

Which “you” opens a respectful first meeting? (آپ, *āp*.) Now add the question word.

You’ll want to know first — کیا

کیا — *kyā* — **what**

Read right to left: ک *k*, ی supplying the *y* glide here, then | long *ā*. The same ی carried long *ī* in جی and نہیں. Its job depends on the word; here the learned shape is *kyā*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu **kyā** and Hindi **kyā** are the same inherited Indo-Aryan word in different scripts. Their history reaches Sanskrit *kim* and the old Indo-European *k/kw*-question family behind English **wh**- words such as *what*, *who*, and *which*. The bridge helps memory; Urdu کیا remains the form

you must read here.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **kyā** — what
- *Read it:* کیا as **k** + **yā**
- *Say it:* the family — **kyā, what, who, which**

Before you move on

Which letter acts as *y* here but as long *ī* in جی (ی.)? What does کیا mean? (**What.**)

3.3 آپ کا نام؟ — ask a name respectfully

Recall **āp** “you,” **kyā** “what,” and the answer **merā nām ... hai**. The question reuses all three.

The exchange

آپ کا نام؟ — *āp kā nām kyā hai?* — **What is your name?**

Build it in spoken order:

you + **kā** + name + what + is?

Āp kā means “your” in this frame. The possessive form agrees with the thing owned: **nām** is masculine singular, so use **kā**. Keep that one pairing; the full *kā/kī/ke* system can wait. As in your answer, **hai** stays at the end.

Script: the question mark

Urdu ends the question with ؟, curved for a right-to-left line. Begin at آپ on the right and reach the punctuation at the far left.

Your turn

- *Say it:* āp k̄ā nām kyā hai?
- *Say it:* ask, then answer — merā nām ... hai
- *Point to:* to ؟ at the end

Before you move on

Ask once without romanization. Where does **hai** remain? (At the end.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

3.4 آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی — pleased to meet you

Ask āp k̄ā nām kyā hai? and answer merā nām ... hai.

This fixed response now closes the meeting.

The exchange

آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی۔ āp se mil kar khushī huī **Pleased to meet you.**

For now, hold three meaning-sized chunks:

- āp se — with you
- mil kar — having met
- khushī huī — happiness happened

That yields the memorable literal picture: “**Having met you, happiness happened.**” The phrase is one social move; later lessons can generalize *se*, *-kar*, and past agreement one at a time.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Khushī “happiness” comes from Persian **khosh/khush** “pleasant, happy.” **Mil** “meet” and **huī** “happened” belong to Urdu’s inherited Indo-Aryan grammar. The sentence therefore joins Urdu’s two major historical layers without becoming any less ordinary Urdu.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- āp se | mil kar | khushī huī in three beats
- the literal picture — “having met you, happiness happened”
- which word came through Persian — **khushī**

Before you move on

Say the response once as a whole. Which chunk means “happiness happened”? (**Khushī huī**.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

3.5 Practice — a complete Urdu name exchange

Recall the four moves without adding anything: greet, ask, answer, acknowledge.

The exchange

A: سلام! — *Salām!* B: سلام! — *Salām!* A: ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ — *Āp kā nām kyā hai?* B: ہے۔ سارا نام میرا — *Merā nām Sārā hai.* A: شکریہ۔ — *Āp se mil kar khushī huī.* B: شکریہ۔ — *Shukriyā.*

Every line is already known. **Āp** keeps the meeting respectful; **hai** stays at the end of both name sentences; ؟ ends the question at the line’s left.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both voices, using your own name
- the exchange again without romanization
- only the three name moves — question, answer, response

Before you move on

Run the meeting once from **salām** to **shukriyā**. If a line stalls, review only that micro-lesson.

Chapter 4

How Are You?

4.1 کیسے / کیسی — “how” follows the addressee

Say **kyā** “what.” Urdu’s next question word begins with the same **k** family, but its ending changes with the person being addressed.

The two words

Urdu	read	use in the respectful question
کیسے	<i>kaise</i>	addressing a man
کیسی	<i>kaisī</i>	addressing a woman

Both begin ک *k* + ی carrying the *ai* sound. At the left edge, کیسے ends in broad ے *e*, while کیسی ends in ی long *ī*. Read the whole word before isolating the final shape.

Grammar Lens: one agreement contrast

English keeps *how* unchanged. Urdu makes this describing form agree with the person addressed: **kaise** for a man, **kaisī** for a woman. Learn only this pair today—not a table of adjective endings. Respectful **āp** itself remains the same for everyone.

Your turn

- Say it: addressing a man — **kaise**
- Say it: addressing a woman — **kaisī**

- *Point to:* broad final ے versus long-ī ی

Before you move on

Which form addresses a man? (**Kaise.**) A woman? (**Kaisī.**)
Source: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation.*

4.2 آپ کیسے ہیں؟ / آپ کیسی ہیں؟ — ask respectfully

Choose respectful **āp**. Then choose **kaise** for a man or **kaisī** for a woman. One final copula completes the question.

The exchange

to a man: آپ کیسے ہیں؟ — *āp kaise haiñ?* to a woman: آپ کیسی ہیں؟
— *āp kaisī haiñ?*

The order is **you + how + are?** Keep ہیں *haiñ* final, just as ہے *hai* stayed final in the name question. Respectful **āp** takes this plural-shaped copula even when speaking to one person.

Grammar Lens: respect does not erase agreement

Both lines are respectful. The choice between **kaise** and **kaisī** tracks the person addressed, not greater or lesser politeness. If you do not know how a person wishes to be addressed, listen for their usage or ask rather than guess; the grammar lesson does not replace social judgment.

Your turn

- *Say it:* to a man — **āp kaise haiñ?**
- *Say it:* to a woman — **āp kaisī haiñ?**
- *Keep:* respectful **āp** and final **haiñ** in both

Before you move on

What stays the same in both lines? (**Āp ... haiñ.**) What changes? (**Kaise / kaisī.**)
Sources: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation and Personal Pronouns with “To Be”.*

4.3 میں ... ہوں — one frame for “I am ...”

Ask **āp kaise haiñ?** You know the respectful “you are” ending **haiñ**. Your answer needs the first-person pair “I ... am.”

You’ll want to know first — the frame

میں ... ہوں — *maiñ ... hūñ* — I am ...

maiñ means “I.” Final ں marks a nasal ending. *hūñ* means “am” and carries long *ū* with و, followed again by nasal ں. Leave a space for the state word that comes next.

Grammar Lens: the verb closes the frame

Urdu puts the copula at the end:

maiñ + [state] + **hūñ** — I + [state] + am

Learn only this first-person frame. You do not need the full copula chart to answer one wellbeing question. Notice the useful contrast: respectful **āp ... haiñ**, but first-person **maiñ ... hūñ**.

Your turn

- Say it: **maiñ** — I
- Say it: **hūñ** — am
- Frame: **maiñ ... hūñ**, leaving the middle open

Before you move on

Which word opens the answer? (**Main.**) Which copula closes it? (**Hūñ.**)

Source: *Basic Urdu*: Personal Pronouns with “To Be”.

4.4 ٹھیک — “fine,” “well,” and “correct”

Open and close the answer frame: **maiñ ... hūñ**. The middle now gets one high-frequency state word.

You'll want to know first — the word

ٹھیک — *ṭhīk* — fine, well, correct

The first sound is retroflex and aspirated: curl the tongue slightly back for ٹ *t*, then release a puff marked by ھ. A plain English *t* is a useful first approximation while the contrast settles. ے carries long *ī* before final ک *k*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu ٹھیک and Hindi *ṭhīk* are the same everyday Hindustani word. Their grammar is closely shared; their scripts make different literary histories visible. This Urdu lesson leaves the Hindi side romanized: mixed-language practice may show both scripts only after each form has been learned in its own track.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **ṭhīk** — fine, well
- *Feel:* tongue slightly back, then a small puff
- *Connect:* Urdu ٹھیک ↔ Hindi *ṭhīk*

Before you move on

Where will **ṭhīk** go in the frame **main̄ ... hūn̄**? (In the middle.)
Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

4.5 شکریہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں — “I am fine, thank you”

Fill the frame **main̄ ... hūn̄** with **ṭhīk**, then recall Chapter 1’s **shukriyā**.

The exchange

ٹھیک میں، شکریہ۔ *Main̄ ṭhīk hūn̄, shukriyā. I am fine, thank you.*

No word is new. The step is assembling the words quickly enough to answer a real person.

Grammar Lens: keep the copula final

The core reply is:

I + fine + am → **maiñ ṭhīk hūñ**

English places “am” after “I”; Urdu closes the clause with **hūñ**. **Shukriyā** comes after the completed answer as the courtesy move you already own.

Your turn

- *Build:* **maiñ + ṭhīk + hūñ**
- *Add:* **shukriyā**
- *Say it:* the full reply without translating each word

Before you move on

Which word must close the core answer? (**Hūñ.**)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation*.

4.6 Practice — an Urdu wellbeing exchange

Choose the question ending for the person addressed, then retrieve the complete answer before looking below.

The exchange

A to a man: سلام! آپ کیسے ہیں؟ *Salām! Āp kaise haiñ?* A to a woman: سلام! آپ کیسی ہیں؟ *Salām! Āp kaisī haiñ?* B: ٹھیک میں شکریہ۔ *Main ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā.*

The question keeps respectful **āp** and final **haiñ** while **kaise/kaisī** agrees with the addressee. The reply is unchanged for the speaker’s gender: **ṭhīk** does not change, and first-person **hūñ** closes the line.

Grammar Lens: separate grammar from guessing

The two question forms are a grammatical contrast, not an instruction to infer someone’s identity. In real interaction, follow the person’s own

language or ask. The stable beginner default is respect: **āp ... haiñ.**

Your turn

- *Say it:* the man-addressed exchange
- *Say it:* the woman-addressed exchange
- *Answer:* **maiñ ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā** after either question

Before you move on

Run both question variants once. If the choice stalls, review only **kaise/kaisī**; if the answer order stalls, review only **maiñ ... hūñ.**

Chapter 5

Take Leave

5.1 خدا — the first half of an Urdu farewell

Run one known wellbeing exchange. Chapter 5 will add only the move that ends it.

You'll want to know first — one word

خدا — *khudā* — God

Read from right to left: خ *kh* + د *d* + ا long *ā*. The short *u* is learned with the word and is normally unwritten. Let **kh** come from farther back than English *h*, but keep the sound relaxed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu borrowed **khudā** from Persian **khodā**, whose older Middle Persian ancestor *xwadāy* meant “lord.” Learn the Urdu sound and script first; the Persian connection then explains why both tracks will share the phrase’s first historical layer.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **khudā** — God
- *Read it:* خدا from the right edge
- *Connect:* Urdu **khudā** ← Persian **khodā**

Before you move on

Which final letter carries long **ā**? (l.) Which short vowel must be remembered with the word? (u.)

Sources: *Basic Urdu*: Greetings and Introductions; Wiktionary: خدا.

5.2 حافظ — “guardian” or “protector”

Read خدا and say **khudā**. Keep it separate while one second word is added.

You’ll want to know first — one word

حافظ — *hāfiz* — guardian, protector

Read ح ا ف ا ح from right to left. ا carries long **ā**. Final ط is pronounced **z** in this Urdu word. The short *i* is heard in **hāfiz** but is normally not written as a separate letter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Arabic **ḥāfiz** is an active participle from **ḥ-f-ẓ**, “guard, preserve.” Urdu receives **hāfiz** through its Persian-Arabic literary layer. Keep “guardian” as the useful meaning; the three-consonant root is a memory hook.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **hāfiz** — guardian, protector
- *Read it*: حافظ
- *Connect*: Arabic **ḥ-f-ẓ** — guard, preserve

Before you move on

What does **hāfiz** contribute to the farewell? (The idea of guarding or protecting.)

Source: American Heritage Dictionary: *hafiz*.

5.3 حافظ خدا — goodbye

Retrieve **khudā** and **hāfiz** separately: “God” + “guardian.”
Now use the two known pieces as one parting move.

The two words — put the known pieces together

حافظ خدا — *khudā hāfiz* — goodbye

Urdu keeps a visible space between the two words. Read خدا first, then حافظ, and preserve that space in the complete spelling حافظ خدا. Say the whole expression smoothly.

Grammar Lens — a whole social move

The protective sense is “God [be] guardian,” but everyday speakers use the formula simply as **goodbye**. No new verb or agreement ending is needed. It is a reliable polite close for the short interaction learned so far.

Script Bridge — shared history, local spacing

Urdu حافظ خدا and Persian خدا حافظ share the same historical pieces. Urdu keeps the visible space in this course; Persian normally joins them. Mixed practice may compare the two only now that each local phrase is independently readable.

Your turn

- *Build:* **khudā** + **hāfiz**
- *Read it:* spaced Urdu حافظ خدا
- *Use:* say it when the interaction ends

Before you move on

Where is the local writing contrast? (Urdu shows a space; Persian joins its spelling.)
Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

5.4 Practice — open, check, and close

Retrieve the known expression for the beginning and the new expression for the end. Keep the middle unchanged.

The exchange — the complete interaction

A: سلام آپ کیسے ہیں؟ *Salām! Āp kaise hain?* B: ہوں، ٹھیک میں *Bon, theek mein.*
 A: شکر ہے۔ *Main shukriya.* B: حافظہ خدا *Khuda hafiz.*
 A: حافظہ خدا *Khuda hafiz.*

Every line is already learned. **Salām** opens; **khudā hāfiz** closes. The same farewell works for both speakers, so this practice adds no gender choice, pronoun, or copula form.

Your turn

- *Choose:* meeting begins → **salām**
- *Choose:* interaction ends → **khudā hāfiz**
- *Run through:* both voices once with script, once without romanization

Before you move on

Run the full exchange once. If the final line stalls, return only to the assembled-farewell lesson.

Chapter 6

Five Verbs at the Core

6.1 ہونا — “to be,” and the ending every Urdu verb wears

You can already close an Urdu sentence with ہوں *hūn* — “am.” That small word is a fragment of something larger. Here is the whole verb it was broken off.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ہونا — *honā* — to be

Read from the right edge: ہ *h*, then ں carrying *o*, then ن *n*, then ا long *ā*. Every one of those four shapes has already turned up in a word you have met. There is nothing new to decode here, which is rare, and worth enjoying.

Grammar Lens: the ending that names every verb

honā ends in -نā. So does every Urdu verb when you name it. English marks a verb’s plain name by putting a word in front — *to be*, *to go*, *to come*. Urdu marks it by putting **-nā** on the end, and never uses a separate word for it.

That ending is also a tool. Strip **-nā** off and what remains is the **stem**, the piece everything else in the verb is built on. **honā** minus **-nā** leaves **ho-**. Learn the ending once, and every new verb hands you its own stem for free.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

honā comes from Sanskrit *bhavati*, “becomes,” built on the root *bhū-*. The middle stage of Indo-Aryan softened that *bh-* to *h-*, so *bhavati* thinned to *hoi* and then to **honā**.

The root is Indo-European: **b^huH-*, “grow, become.” English kept it in **be** and **been**, and — by way of “the place where one dwells” — in **build**, **booth**, and **bower**. Latin held it as *fuī* “I was” and *futūrus*, which English borrowed as **future**. Greek held it as *phúsis* “nature,” which English borrowed as **physics**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **honā** — to be
- *Strip:* **honā** minus **-nā** leaves the stem **ho-**
- *Read it:* ہونا from the right edge
- *Connect:* **honā** ← Sanskrit *bhavati* → English **be**

Before you move on

Which ending names an Urdu verb? (**-nā**.) What is left of *honā* once you take that ending off? (**Ho-**.) Which English verb grew from the same ancient root? (**Be**.)

Sources: *Basic Urdu*: Personal Pronouns with “To Be”; Wiktionary: ہونا.

6.2 جانا — “to go,” and two agreements in one sentence

Take the ending off **honā** and say the stem aloud. The next verb gives that same ending a second workout.

You’ll want to know first — one word

جانا — *jānā* — to go

From the right edge: ج *j*, then | long *ā*, then ن *n*, then | long *ā*. The ج *j* is the one from جی *jī*. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **jā-**.

Grammar Lens: the present tense agrees twice

“I go” in Urdu is two words after the pronoun, not one:

میں ہوں جاتا — *main jātā hūñ* — I go (man speaking) میں
ہوں جاتی — *main jātī hūñ* — I go (woman speaking)

The first word is the stem **jā-** plus **-tā**. It says *going*, and it agrees with the **gender and number** of the person doing it: **-tā** for one man, **-tī** for one woman, **-te** for more than one man or for a respectful singular. The second word is **hūñ**, which you already own, and it agrees with **person** — who is speaking.

Two agreements, split across two words, in one short clause. English makes one agreement at most, and usually none. Say both Urdu lines and let the difference sit in the ear rather than on paper.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jānā continues Sanskrit *yāti*, “goes,” from the root *yā-*, “travel.” The change from *y-* to *j-* is not a quirk of this word: initial *y-* regularly hardened to *j-* on the road from Sanskrit into the middle stage of Indo-Aryan that Urdu descends from. Meet the law once and it decodes other words later.

English gives nothing here. The *yā-* root travelled north and west into Lithuanian and Slavic rather than into Germanic, so this is a word where Sanskrit is the whole hook and English cannot help.

Your turn

- Say it: **jānā** — to go
- Strip: **jānā** minus **-nā** leaves **jā-**
- Say it: **main jātā hūñ**, then **main jātī hūñ**
- Choose: the ending that fits you — **-tā** or **-tī**

Before you move on

Which word in *main jātā hūñ* carries gender? (**Jātā** — the one built on the stem.) Which one carries person? (**Hūñ**.) And which Sanskrit verb stands behind *jānā*? (*Yā-*, “travel.”)

Source: Wiktionary: جانا.

6.3 اُآ — “to come,” which is “go” pointed back at you

Say **jānā**, then its stem **jā-**. The opposite direction is the same verb wearing a prefix.

You’ll want to know first — one word

اُآ — ānā — to come

From the right edge: ِ, then ن *n*, then ا long *ā*. That first shape is *alif madd* — alif wearing a small wave — and it is how Urdu writes a long *ā* at the start of a word. It opens آ *āp* too. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **ā-**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ānā continues Sanskrit *āyāti*, and that word is two pieces: *ā-*, “toward,” plus *yā-*, “go.” So the Urdu verb for *coming* is, underneath, the verb for *going* aimed back at the speaker. “Go toward me” is “come.”

You already have the second piece: *yā-* is the same root that hardened into the **j-** of **jānā**. One Sanskrit verb, two Urdu words, and the difference between them is a direction marker.

English does the identical trick with a Latin verb: *venīre* “to come” plus a prefix gives **advent**, **convene**, **intervene**, **prevent**, and **revenue**. Urdu welds its prefix on the front and lets the seam disappear; English keeps the seam visible.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **ānā** — to come
- *Pair:* **jānā** away, **ānā** toward
- *Split:* *ā-* “toward” + *yā-* “go”
- *Read it:* اُآ, starting from *alif madd*

Before you move on

Which two pieces are hiding inside *ānā*? (*Ā*- “toward” and *yā*- “go.”)
 Which Urdu verb shares the second piece? (**Jānā**.) And what does the stem become once **-nā** comes off? (*Ā*-.)

Source: Wiktionary: *آ*.

6.4 بولنا — “to speak,” and the two layers of Urdu

Three verbs so far, three stems pulled off the same ending. Here is a fourth, and it brings one new letter with it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

بولنا — *bolnā* — **to speak**

From the right edge: ب *b*, then و carrying *o*, then ل *l*, then ن *n*, then ا long *ā*. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **bol-**.

ب is new, and it is worth one careful second. Its body is a single low scoop with **one dot below**. You have already read پ *p* in آپ *āp*, and پ is that identical scoop with **three dots below**. Same skeleton, different dot count, different consonant. Urdu builds much of its alphabet this way, so counting dots is a real reading skill and not a fussy detail.

Grammar Lens: put it in the frame

The stem takes the same two-agreement frame as before:

ہوں بولتا میں — *main boltā hūn* — **I speak** (man speaking)
 ہوں بولتی میں — *main boltī hūn* — **I speak** (woman speaking)

Nothing new is being learned there. That is the point of a stem: the machine is already built, and each verb just walks into it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bolnā goes back to Prakrit *bolai*, “speaks” — and then the trail stops. A link onward to Sanskrit *brūte* “speaks” has been proposed, but it is not settled, so treat it as a maybe rather than a fact. That plainness is the lesson. Urdu’s everyday verbs are inherited Indo-Aryan and often short-rooted like this, while its formal and literary

vocabulary was borrowed from Persian and Arabic and tends to be long, elegant, and easy to trace. Beside homely **bolnā** sits Persian-derived گفتگو *guftagū*, “conversation,” from Persian *guftan*, “to speak.” Both are fully Urdu. One is the floor of the house; the other is the ornament on it — and the flowing *nastaʿlīq* hand Urdu is traditionally written in belongs to that same Persian inheritance.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **bolnā** — to speak
- *Count:* ب one dot below, پ three dots below
- *Say it:* **maiṅ boltā hūṅ**, then **maiṅ boltī hūṅ**
- *Sort:* **bolnā** inherited, **guftagū** borrowed

Before you move on

How many dots does ب carry, and where? (One, below.) How far back can *bolnā* be traced with confidence? (To Prakrit *bollaï*, and no further.) Which layer of Urdu does *guftagū* belong to? (The Persian one.)

Sources: *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet; Wiktionary: بولنا.

6.5 جانا — “to know,” a word English has been carrying all along

Run the four verbs you have — *honā*, *jānā*, *ānā*, *bolnā* — and pull the stem off each one. The fifth is the closest of them to English.

You’ll want to know first — one word

جانا — *jānnā* — to know

From the right edge: ج *j*, | long *ā*, then ن, then ن a second time, then | long *ā*. Two separate nūns, written out one after the other, and both are pronounced: hold the *n* long, *jān-nā*, the way English does across the seam of *thin · ness*. Strip the final *-nā* and the stem is **jān-**.

That doubling is what keeps **jānnā** “to know” apart from **jānā** “to go.” One letter, and the whole meaning turns.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jānnā continues Sanskrit *jānāti*, from the root *jñā-*, “know.” That root is Indo-European **ǵneh₃-*, and English is stuffed with it.

Straight down the Germanic line: **know**, **knowledge**, **can** (once “to know how”), **cunning**, **ken**, and **uncouth** — literally “un-known.” Borrowed from Latin (*g*)*nōscere*: **notice**, **note**, **notion**, **cognition**, **recognize**, **acquaint**, and **ignore**, which is “not to know.” Borrowed from Greek *gnōsis*: **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, and **agnostic**.

So the Urdu verb is not a stranger. It is a first cousin of the plainest word English has for the same idea, and every one of those borrowings is another place to hang it.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **jānnā** — to know, holding the long *n*
- *Contrast*: **jānā** to go, **jānnā** to know
- *Say it*: **maiñ jāntā hūñ**, then **maiñ jāntī hūñ**
- *Run through*: all five — *honā*, *jānā*, *ānā*, *bolnā*, *jānnā* — stripping each stem
- *Connect*: **jānnā** ← *jñā-* → English **know**, **notice**, **diagnosis**

Before you move on

What single written difference separates *jānā* from *jānnā*? (A second ن, held long in speech.) Which two words in *maiñ jāntī hūñ* agree, and with what? (**Jāntī** with gender, **hūñ** with person.) And which English verb is the same word as *jānnā*? (**Know**.)

Source: Wiktionary: جَانَا.

A note on sources

Script descriptions follow Northwestern University’s open Zero Zabar Urdu-alphabet materials. Chapter 4’s wellbeing forms and register contrast, together with Chapter 5’s farewell, follow Michigan State University’s open *Basic Urdu*.